ESSAY · OCTOBER 2026

The Joy of the Question

AI will solve more and more of our problems. What stays ours is choosing them, and caring about them.

Stéphane Cuenat

The oldest fear

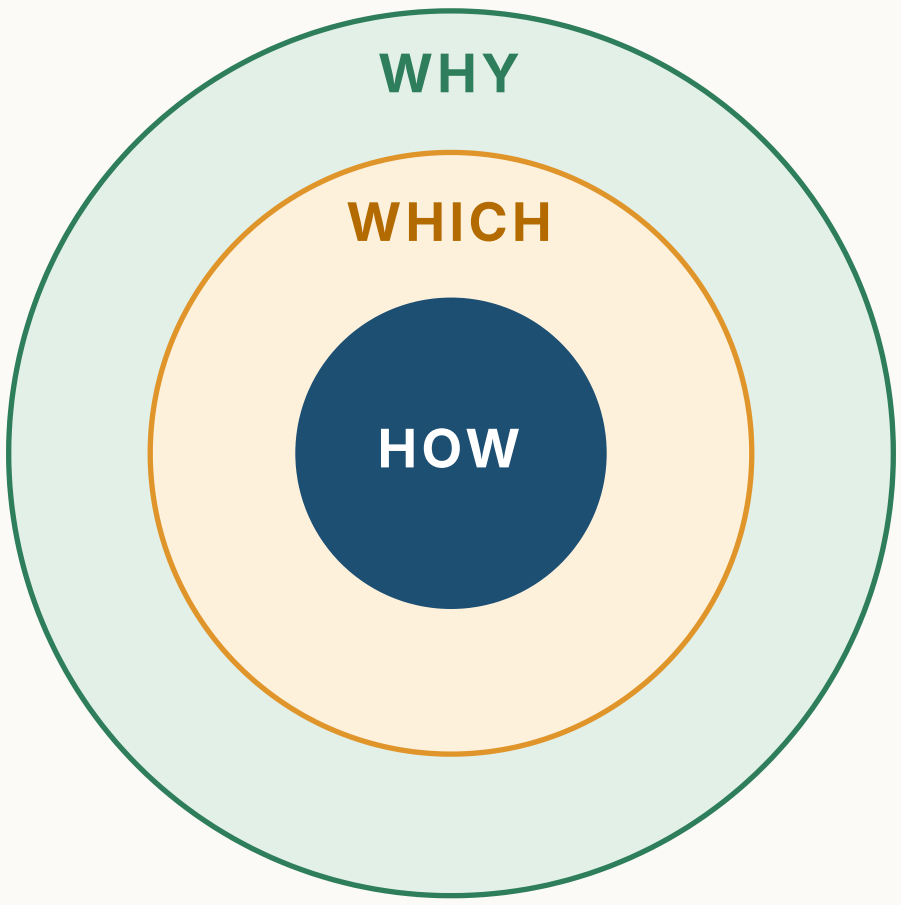
> *“The appearance of wisdom, not true wisdom.”*

King Thamus, on the invention of writing. Plato, *Phaedrus*

Twenty-four centuries later, we ask the same question about AI. It reached gold-medal level at the Maths Olympiad in 2025 and settled problems open for decades in 2026.

What will this do to us?

Speed is the machine's game



HOW · solve
Machines: take more of it every year

WHICH · which problem, what counts as a good answer
Imagination and judgement: a person frames and checks

WHY · why it matters at all
Ours to bring: a reason to care

"Whoever has a why to live can bear almost any how."
Nietzsche

Losing work, gaining height

5.8 million

moves by professional Go players, 1950–2021

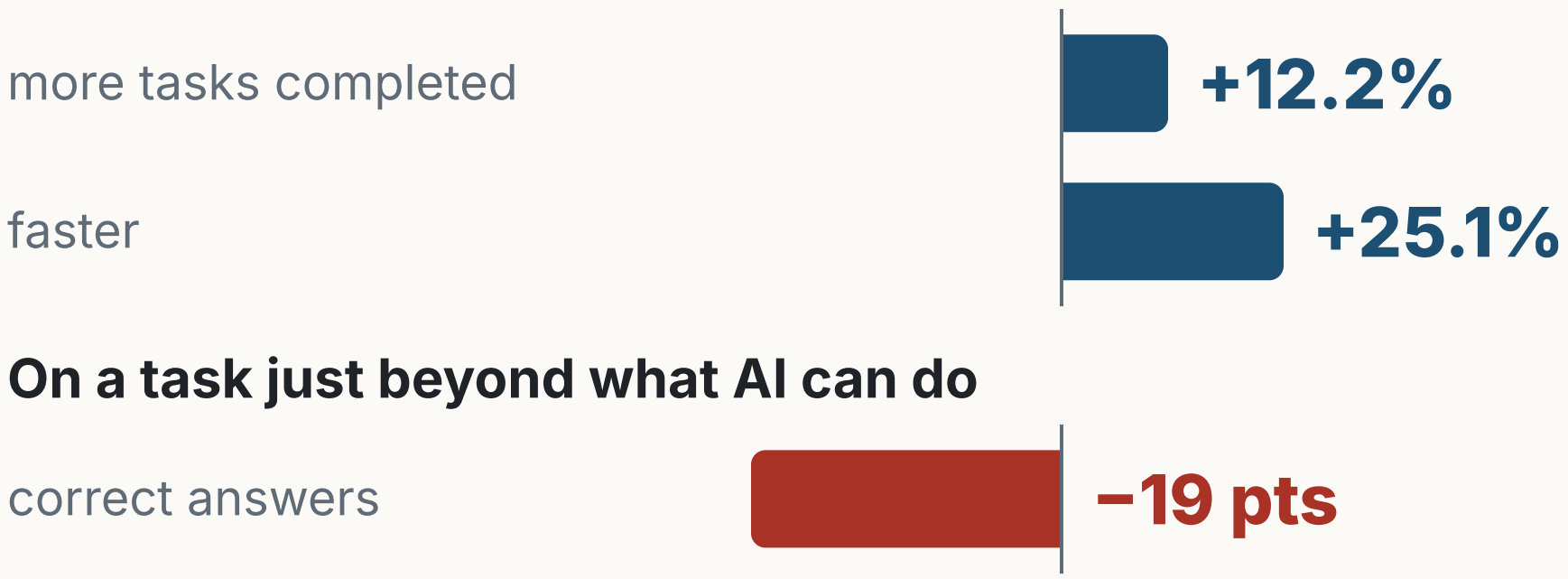
After superhuman AI arrived in 2016, human moves became **better**, and **more novel**. The machines did not end the game. The game turned out to be bigger than people thought.

Shin et al., *PNAS*, 2023. An association, not proof of cause.

Same tool, different results

758 consultants with AI, compared with colleagues without it

On tasks AI does well



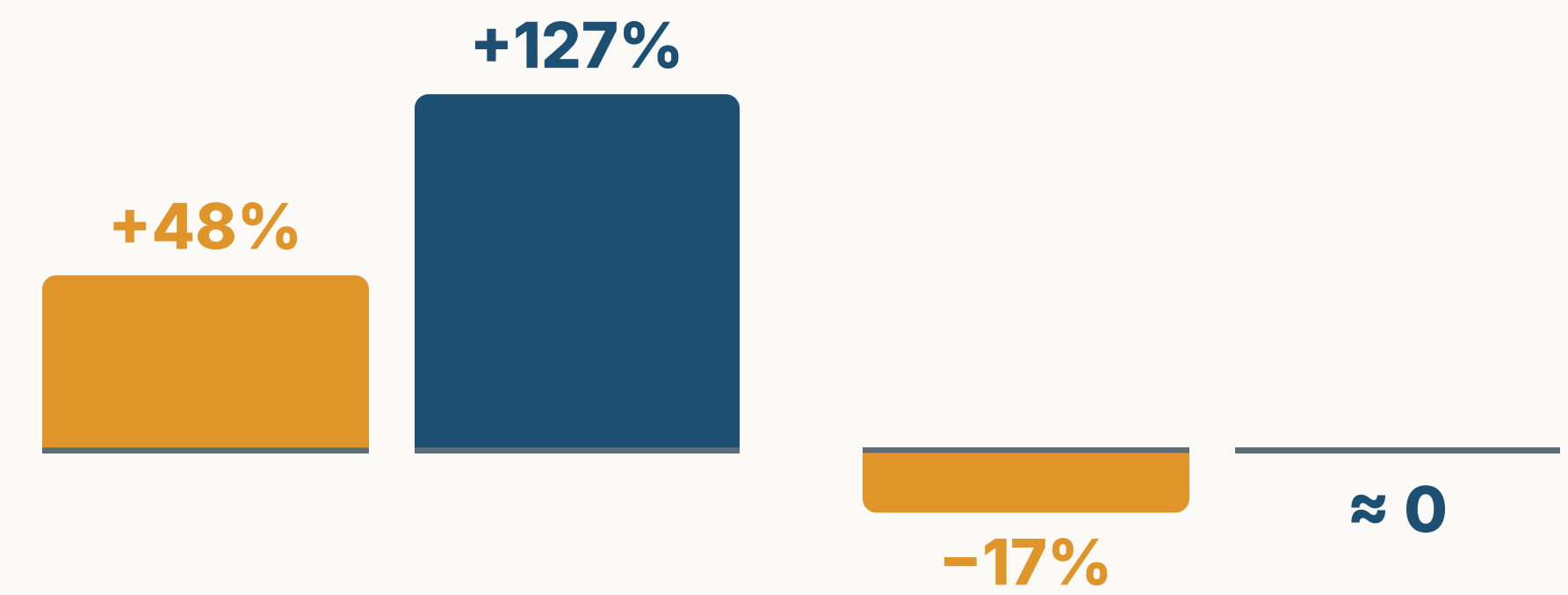
On a task just beyond what AI can do

The tool did not say where its competence ended.
Knowing that was the person's job.

Dell'Acqua et al., *Organization Science*, 2026

Effort builds the skill

~1,000 high-school students practised maths with AI. Grades compared with students who never had AI.



- Plain chat assistant
- Tutor that gives hints, not answers

With the plain assistant, students learned less than with no AI at all. **Designed to keep the effort, the tutor did no harm.**

Bastani et al., *PNAS*, 2025

A well-made head

> *"Better a well-made head than a well-filled one."*

Montaigne, *Essais*, 1580

Information
you read it or were given it

Sourced
you know where it comes from

Tested
you know what would prove it wrong

Connected
it fits with what you know

Knowledge
you can explain and defend it without the tool

AI can fill any head. **The making is still ours.**

What a machine has no reason to want

> *“One must imagine Sisyphus happy.”*
>
> Albert Camus, 1942

A machine may one day reach the top of every hill faster than we can. But being there first is not the same as being glad to be there.

The motivation to begin, the meaning found on the way, the joy of understanding something yourself: **that is the reason any of it is worth doing.**

What to do

For ourselves

- → Write the question before opening the tool
- → Decide what a good answer looks like
- → Keep doing some things by hand, for the pleasure and the skill

For our children

- → Let them try first
- → Teach them to ask “how do you know?”
- → Reward good questions as much as right answers
- → Leave room for boredom and play

The machine will find answers. Whether they matter, and the joy of looking for them, is up to us.

Full essay, sources and figure code

scuenat.github.io

Questions or objections? Comment below.